Register reports that, about a year later, in November 1908, he jumped ship to become captain of the *Caspian*.[117]

The other members of *Gallia*'s crew included Robert Lesley Bewick (born in Newcastle in 1882, he had won his certification as mate/chief officer only a year earlier[118]) and F. Gilles, the chief engineer.[119] By September next year, the captain was W. Francis, replacing Chapman, while the chief engineer was T.A. Boase.[120]

In early 1908, Alex Flett was the captain of the *Lawoe*. There were reports that Captain Flett, hired on a monthly salary of Rs 450, was leaving the company in February 1908 for a better paid position. It was said that 'he acted and worked like an Indian' and won the affection of both merchants and passengers.[121] But later in the year, there was a change of guard. By September 1908, the *Lawoe* was helmed by Captain R.W. Cooper while its chief engineer was Flett. It is not clear if the latter was the same Alex Flett, the earlier captain.[122]

It also needs to be borne in mind that a ship's crew, by definition, had to be rotated. Captains and other officers could not obviously be on the seas all around the year and necessarily took long breaks in between contracts. Perhaps that explains the conflict even in the limited evidence that we have been able to gather.

Rate Wars

With the induction of a good fleet and an experienced crew in place, SSNCo had signalled that the Swadeshi company was no flash in the pan. Gone were the days of uncertainty when it was dependent on untrustworthy shipping magnates and their chartered ships.

Quickly, SSNCo won over the entire cargo traffic with an overwhelming majority of Tuticorin traders using its steamers for freight. As S.D. Krishna Aiyangar recalled, 'We had a monopoly of cargo traffic, of course, with some exception. It was only in the matter of passenger traffic that BI competed with us.' However, as even he conceded, 'without passenger